



MUT Acting VC, Professor Marcus Ramogale, left, with Dr Godson Gatsha, middle, and Cyril Ndaba, form SA Consulate in California, US, and the UK, at the inaugural I-Week

MUT ON THE GLOBAL STAGE

Inaugural International Week a resounding success

The week of 22 to 26 November 2021 will go down in MUT's history as a decisive step towards forging strong links with the international community. The University hosted its inaugural International Week (I-Week), with participants from Europe, Africa, the United States of America (USA) and Canada.

Participants also included representatives of local universities, eThekweni Municipality, Moses Kotane Institute and MUT staff. One of the highlights of the week was the participation of the chief executives of organisations such as the CIDB and the endorsement by MUT's founder, Prince Mangosuthu Buthelezi. Engaging with the international community is part of the University's Strategy 2025, which calls for an "internationalisation agenda".

Professor 'Hal' Walker, and his wife, Dr Bettye Walker, on screen, were guests at the I-Week. On the foreground is Professor Ramogale



MUT pays tribute to its Founder and a moon landing icon

One of the highlights of I-Week was the participation of two great movers and shakers, MUT's internationally renowned and respected founder, Prince Mangosuthu Buthelezi, and Professor Hildreth 'Hal' Walker, a man who was responsible for the landing of Apollo 11 on the moon in 1969. They met each other about two years ago, together with Hal's wife Dr Bettye Walker, and at I-Week the trio continued from where they left off. Education is their mutual passion and they talked about how the country's youth could benefit from such.

In February 2019, the Walkers opened the first chapter of the National Space Society in Cape Town, and they have now proposed opening one at MUT – an education landmark for His Royal Highness, Prince Buthelezi. This will be a continuation of his dream of empowering people through education. Prince Buthelezi is known for bringing education centres to where people live, which



On screen, is the Founder of the University, His Royal Highness, Prince Mangosuthu Buthelezi, left and Professor Ramogale. Prince Buthelezi supported the I-Week

is the opposite of what happened to him: he had to leave home for his secondary and university education at Adams College and Fort Hare University, respectively.

Acting Vice-Chancellor and Principal, Professor Marcus Ramogale paid tribute to these pioneers for their contribution to education and community development and expressed his confidence that Prince Buthelezi will continue to support MUT.

- ◆ *"The Walkers work in our country is truly inspiring. By the time they*
- ◆ *opened the first chapter of the National Space Society on the African*
- ◆ *continent in February 2018, they had already established computer literacy laboratories and STEM programmes in a number of schools in South Africa's townships."* – Prince Buthelezi

Patron of MUT Internationalisation plays his part

MUT's inaugural International Week was backed by none other than South Africa's former Consul-General, Mr Cyril Ndaba. Known to the University for opening doors for it in the UK and the US, he was the ideal choice of patron to assist MUT in preparing and running the event.

Ndaba believes that empowerment should be at the heart of the relationship between a university and its stakeholders. Using his networks, he worked with the University, from the Vice-Chancellor to the event coordination team.

"Based on my global experience, I have observed that countries that make use of their diplomatic corps to advance internationalisation benefit more than those that do not integrate the internationalisation of higher education. Since my return from California, I



Cyril Ndaba at one of the I-Week sessions

have taken it upon myself to ensure that we elevate MUT and position it globally," said Ndaba.

His determination to elevate MUT saw him consulting globally to help draw attention to the University. This brought participants from the US, UK and some parts of Africa. He also facilitated networking with California State University, Professor Hildreth 'Hal' Walker and his wife Dr Bettye Walker.

Leveraging international visibility for MUT in California

One of the speakers at MUT's International Week was Professor Boatomo Mosupye, Associate Dean for Resource and Programme Management at California State University in Sacramento, California. Originally from Johannesburg, Mosupye has a similar passion to MUT's patron of internationalisation, Mr Ndaba.

"I come to MUT's Internationalisation Week bearing in mind that California was a hive of anti-apartheid activities and made considerable contributions in education, the arts and political activities to ensure that our fellow Africans could make a better society. I am also inspired by the foundation that the former Consul-General has laid in the state of California for our higher education system to play a pivotal role in the upliftment of SA's higher education system," she said.

Mosupye has offered a number of opportunities to MUT, including student, staff, faculty and administrators' exchange programmes. Her objectives are to help MUT to:

- develop awareness of international dynamics;
- gain exposure to innovative learning methods;
- build a stepping stone to personal growth for students, staff, faculty and administrators;
- plan for the world economy;
- increase its global perspective;
- increase chances of employability;
- create life-long bonds; and
- increase literacy in navigating diverse global environments.

"I am driven by a desire to ensure that an employee in higher education or a student in a higher education environment should at a certain point in their lives have been outside South Africa. Being international is life-changing. I will be keeping my ear to the ground



Professor Boatomo Mosupye, right, with the star of Oscar Winner Movie Tsotsi, Preseley Chweneyagae at the 14th Africa Day Celebration Gala Dinner, June 2 2006, Beverly Hills Hotel, Beverly Hills, California



Professor Boatomo Mosupye and the Consul-General of South Africa Her Excellency Jeanette Ndhlovu (Facebook)

on how we could partner with MUT. I am already eying some existing peer programmes as well as emerging leadership programmes as a strategic fit to how I could work with MUT," concluded Mosupye.

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◆ or a student in a higher education environment should at a certain point
◆ in their lives have been outside South Africa. Being international is life-changing." – Professor Boatomo Mosupye

Tech business leader and entrepreneur commends MUT students on choosing entrepreneurship

As unemployment continues to rise in South Africa, it has never been clearer that entrepreneurship could be the potential answer to job creation and to solving societal problems.

This was the message from Dr Oluyomi Ajayi, Chief Executive Officer of Siyacanda Energy, when he made a presentation to a virtual audience at Mangosuthu University of Technology's inaugural International Week, which ran from 22-26 November 2021.

Dr Ajayi said that studies indicated that many young people are in favour of starting their own businesses. This is very true at MUT. MUT students have identified gaps in the market, and started their different businesses based on these facts. Nombulelo Ncube, Advanced Diploma in Human Resources student, said whilst employed at a Human Resources (HR) firm, she felt that she could do more than what she was doing there, and decided to start her own business. Nombulelo is the owner of an HR consulting business. She is one of six MUT students that took part in the International Week. The students introduced their businesses to the virtual audience. These students heeded a call from the University management, particularly Professor Marcus Ramogale, the Acting Vice-Chancellor & Principal, to seriously consider starting their businesses, and become job creators. No one was born to be an employee; Professor Ramogale is known to have said.

The students are doing well under the tutelage of Ntombifuthi Mthembu, a Lecturer in the Department of Human Resources at the University. They took part in the annual EDHE (Entrepreneurship Development in Higher Education) competition. Wandile Sihya went as far as the national level of the competition. He has a business that cleans house roofs.

Emphasizing the need for students to start their businesses sooner rather than later, Dr Ajayi said all that was required was "to have a business mind-set, and not wait until you have a PhD". He said the now powerful businesses like Microsoft, Google, Facebook,



Dr Oluyomi Ajayi

etc, were started by students while they were still in college. In South Africa, Keaton Harris started InforMED. This became a global winning venture. Dr Ajayi told the students not to be afraid to fail.

"Time and age are on your side", he said. "Learn from your mistakes." He advised them to network with other people. "Also, talk to your mentor, to your teacher. Just start," he said. "There are many types of business you can start while you are still on campus."

Mthembu said that the students needed to be given more time to look after their businesses.

Xolile Ngubane, Acting Director of the Technology Station in Chemicals at MUT, pointed out that self-employment was critical. "Entrepreneurship transforms economies. Innovation is the backbone of the modern business," Ngubane said.

All speakers agreed that growth entrepreneurship will reduce unemployment, particularly that of unemployed graduates. They advised the South African youth to follow in the footsteps of their counterparts in Africa and the rest of the world. Dr Ajayi, a serious world traveller, said South African youth are less likely to go into business, compared to the rest of the continent's youth.

"Entrepreneurship transforms economies. Innovation is the backbone of the modern business." – Xolile Ngubane



The spirit of entrepreneurship at MUT is fully supported by staff and business leaders

MUT GETS BEHIND STUDENT ENTREPRENEURSHIP

“MUT students are making it big in business”

Premier promoter of student entrepreneurial skills at MUT, Acting Vice-Chancellor and Principal, Professor Marcus Ramogale, has found a more than willing ally in cultivating this philosophy.

Ntombifuthi Mthembu, a lecturer in the Department of Human Resource Management, has become the face of student entrepreneurship at the University. On 6 and 7 October 2021, Mthembu and colleagues from her department – including the equally enthusiastic Eddie Selebi – gathered with students on the University’s North Campus to share ideas on business and its central role in changing people’s lives. The was part of the national Student Entrepreneurship Week.

Mthembu, the coordinator of the campaign, said MUT wants students to consider entrepreneurship as an

alternative to formal employment. “This event gave students an opportunity to showcase their businesses in whatever form. This year they are showcasing entrepreneurship through storytelling and evidence of their business activities. It was very inspiring to listen to our current and past students sharing their entrepreneurial journey and experiences with other students,” she said.

Thirteen student businesses falling into three categories: ideation stage, existing, and agri. businesses, participated. Mthembu said this was an indication “that the seed of entrepreneurship has been planted at MUT. We have the responsibility of nurturing and assisting student entrepreneurs to have the courage to take their businesses to the next level”.

She added that it is important that businesses that are currently in the ideation stage progress to the next level: “Ideas must be turned into action.” She noted



Ntombifuthi Mthembu

that MUT students are playing a meaningful role in many sectors, with healthy business turnover.

Ithembalamazubane, owned by Zuzile Mthiya, a student in the Department of Human Resource Management, produces and sells white and brown sugar beans. Musa Mkhize, from the same department farms sugarcane and bananas and supplies Umfolozi Sugar Mill. Nompilo Vilakazi, an engineering student, grows chickens and supplies one of the big retailers in KwaZulu-Natal.

“These students have classes to attend and tests to write, but are still able to do such amazing things. All the presenters had amazing stories to tell,” said Mthembu.

Alumni also had the chance to talk about their businesses, including Sabelo Madiba (Blackhorse Group), Ntuthuko Khathi (Khathi Charcoal); and Simphiwe Goniwe and Sanele Shandu (Isiqalo Institute in Academics). They all advised students to learn to do



Wandile Sihiya, went as far as the national level of the EDHE competition.

something for themselves and to “not hesitate to take calculated risks, and be resilient”.

The second day consisted of interactive workshops with students. Kwazi Bhengu from Sibani Consulting highlighted the importance of personal entrepreneurship competencies and discussed behavioural indicators. Ndumiso Ncala, an Information Officer from the Small Enterprise Development Agency (SEDA), outlined SEDA’s mandate in implementing the government’s small business strategy, the sectors supported by SEDA, and the role played by the Small Enterprise Finance Agency (SEFA) in assisting small businesses to secure finance. Ncala encouraged students to keep abreast of the opportunities advertised by SEDA and to seek assistance in applying for them.

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- ◆ *progress to the next level: ‘Ideas must be turned into action.’ She noted*
- ◆ *that MUT students are playing a meaningful role in many sectors, with healthy business turnover. – Ntombifuthi Mthembu*

MUT 'WELLNESS'

MUT gets yet another clean financial audit

Over more than a decade, MUT has received consecutive unqualified audits from external auditors. The external audit is a statutory requirement regarded by many as the equivalent of a “clean bill of health” for a patient. This type of report is issued when the organisation’s financial condition, position and operations are fairly presented in the accounts.

“I am heartened that in 2020, we once more maintained high-level standards in the financial management of the University. We have come a long way as a University. To receive an unqualified audit, especially during an unprecedented year of a series of lockdowns, deserves the highest accolades. I am grateful to everyone that contributed to this clean bill of health for the University,” said Professor Marcus Ramogale, Acting Vice-Chancellor and Principal.

The University’s Chief Financial Officer, Rodney Delomoney, said in terms of audit outcomes, an unqualified audit report is excellent as this means that the annual financial statements comply in all material respects with the relevant regulations – which for MUT would be the International Financial Reporting Standards (IFRS) and the requirements of the Higher Education Act.



Rodney Delomoney

“It also confirms that no other material discrepancies were identified by the auditors,” said Delomoney. He added that this was achieved through proper planning, and ensuring that during the financial year, MUT adhered to relevant processes and systems, as well improving them.

“This required significant effort from all finance staff directly and indirectly involved in the audit while navigating the various challenges of the COVID-19 pandemic,” said Delomoney.

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Staff check their health status during Wellness Day

One of the reasons why people are living longer lives is the availability of medicine and improvements in science and technology. Another factor is how they respond to wellness advice from relevant professionals. The latter is as, if not more, important as taking medication for an ailment. It is for this reason that MUT's Human Resources and Development department invites staff to its annual Wellness Day.

On 28 October 2021, many staff headed to the University's Seme Hall to check their health status with various service providers. Some staff drove there, some boarded the University bus and others walked. They left with a smile and an added spring in their steps.

Safety, Health and Environmental Officer at MUT, Lizwi Masedo, highlighted the importance of staff knowing their health status. "If you know your health status you can take the necessary steps if there is problem. If you do not have to do anything, it will confirm that

you are looking after yourself. This will motivate you to continue doing what you have been doing."

Staff were able to check their blood pressure, HIV status, and body mass index (BMI), have a pap smear (in the University Clinic), and consult with financial institutions.

The service providers recommended that staff check their health status at least twice a year, eat healthily and get regular exercise.

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A staff member having his eyes checked

MUT Bodybuilding team dominates USSA games

University sports were one of the casualties of the covid-19 pandemic, with sporting activities cancelled in fear of them becoming a platform where the virus spreads. As South Africa continues to roll out its vaccination, university sporting calendars are slowly resuming in various institutions, much to the delight of the sporting community.

For Mangosuthu University of Technology (MUT), the resumption of sporting activities has also offered students an opportunity to represent the university at the University Sports South Africa (USSA) games. This opportunity fell on the MUT Bodybuilding team on 5 December 2021 as they compete at the University of Zululand against students from six other universities in the USSA games.

The MUT Bodybuilding team produced an excellent performance, demonstrating that the team has been preparing throughout the lockdowns.

Njabulo Gasa, final year Human Resources student, placed first in Classic Bodybuilding category. His coach Zolani Khoza, final year Construction Management and Quantity Surveying student, placed second in the Open Bodybuilding men's category, under 75 Kg. Mdingi Memela, another final year student, placed second in the Men's Physique category, as was Ntobeko Nzuza, a second year Bachelor of Applied Sciences student. Audrey Sibambo, a third year Electrical Engineering student, placed second in Classic Physique.

The women's team also claimed silverware, shattering stereotypes about the sport being for men. In the Ladies Wellness category, Phindile Ngubane, a second-year Diploma in Agriculture student, placed second, while Nontokozo Zungu, a first year Construction Management and Quantity Surveying student, placed third.

A day before, these bodybuilders competed at Durban's former Clairwood Racecourse, where both Khoza and Gasa placed first. Nzuza and Memela placed second. This was an open competition called Sunfest Arnold Qualifier Show.

Khoza said he was proud of his team's performance.

"The other universities dominated us with numbers, but we definitely dominated them with the quality of muscle. We still need to grow the sport though, especially in



Zolani Khoza, middle, with other participants (picture supplied)



MUT Body Building coach, Nothando Magwaza



Leading example! Zolani Khoza (picture supplied)

making students understand what bodybuilding is all about, and the character and discipline it builds in a person," said Khoza.

IT&N rolls out the digital transformation

One of the great lessons of the COVID-19 pandemic is that humanity will have to rely on technology not only for communication but also to carry out tasks remotely. For universities, this means having digital infrastructure that can withstand modern technological demands.

For institutions such as Mangosuthu University of Technology (MUT), this meant embarking on a journey towards the transformation of the university's digital infrastructure. The Information Technology & Network Department (IT&N) has already started making this transformation a reality.

Dr Marlo de Swardt, Senior Director in the Department said: "We have recently procured and replaced old server infrastructure that houses critical systems in the main campus datacentre".

The project forms part of the foundation being outlaid for the University's five-year digital road map transformation.

Considered a key milestone for MUT, Dr de Swardt said that this initiative is meant to improve operational efficiency within the University IT landscape.



Dr Marlo de Swardt
(photo supplied)

"It is also meant to provide enhanced technology and expand on these offerings to the University community. This new infrastructure will significantly improve bandwidth capacity and accessibility to the MUT community making use of the relevant IT systems. Furthermore, it is beneficial for the University to also keep our technology refreshed and aligned with current and newer IT trends emerging in local and global markets," continued Dr de Swardt.

The 'Server, Storage, and Firewall Refresh' began in September 2021 and was completed on 30 November 2021. Dr de Swardt said that they had challenges in getting the equipment into the country.

He added that the project would enable the University to benchmark and stay ahead of other higher education institutions by adding an improved IT security layer to protect the University intellectual property.

This development enables the capability to install an additional 155 Wi-Fi access points on and around campus, driving what is considered "the foundation for a smart campus concept".

Mass WiFi in campus and residences to increase connectivity

The 'Server, Storage, and Firewall Refresh' was followed by a roll out of extended WiFi capability throughout campus, as well as in all internal (on-campus) and external (off-campus) student residences to support blended teaching and learning modes within the University. The extended WiFi capability is also to provide enhanced internet access and network connectivity to expand on these offerings to the University community.

"The new WiFi infrastructure will significantly improve network capability and accessibility to the MUT student community making use of the relevant IT systems such as Blackboard, Student email and Microsoft Teams for e-learning," said Dr de Swardt. There will be 155 WiFi access points installed throughout campus to provide faster, more robust and reliable internet access.

At present, there are two projects underway, Core WiFi and the External WiFi for student residences, which began in October 2021 and July 2020, respectively. The External WiFi for Student Residences is a three-year project and will be completed in 2023, while the Core WiFi project will be completed in January 2022.

Dr de Swardt said these projects are beneficial for the University to equip all our students for onsite, remote and off-site learning due to COVID-19. This is called a blended and hybrid learning approach being adopted by MUT, similar to other universities.

Dr de Swardt said these projects ensured the University stay ahead of the curve in respect to other higher education institutions transitioning to a fully online smart campus in the near future.

Projects such as these will form part of the foundation being outlaid for the University's five-year digital road map transformation strategy (2022 – 2026).

MUT has internet connections all over the campus

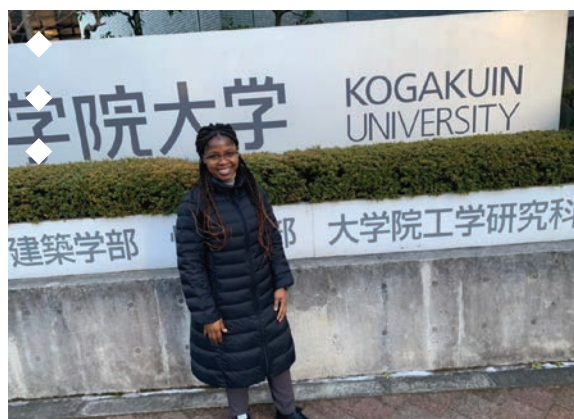


The network is driven by a powerful server system

ALUMNI IN ACTION

Engineering's "best" student of 2010 studying in Japan to solve problems in SA

It is wonderful to hear how our graduates are doing beyond MUT. With so many graduates in South Africa struggling to find jobs, it is also exciting to share success stories to inspire us. Nomvelo Nzimande's story is one of these. After graduating in 2010 as the "best student" in the Faculty of Engineering, she decided to do more.



Nomvelo in Japan (photo supplied)

In the same year she graduated, she enrolled for a B. Tech degree at the Durban University of Technology. In June 2011, she started teaching Mathematics and Electrical Technology in Durban's Chesterville Secondary School while continuing with her studies. In February 2012, Nomvelo joined Eskom Grootvlei power station as a project technician. She worked in different positions at Eskom power stations between 2014 and 2020 and also enrolled with Craine Field College for an Advanced Diploma in Project Management.

In October 2020, Nomvelo was on the move again. She enrolled with Kogakuin University of Technology and Engineering in Japan, and in April 2021 she began her Master's degree in Electrical and Electronics Engineering. She is one of 6,317 students in this private Tokyo university which is more than 130 years old.

Nomvelo's research study focuses on the integration of large-scale photovoltaic (PV) and wind power generation in the national electricity grid. This topic is most appropriate for South Africa which has been dogged by an energy crisis since 2008, with the term "load shedding" one of the most familiar in South Africans' vocabulary.

In April 2022, 12 months into her two-year study period, Nomvelo will spend six months doing an internship in a Japanese company before returning home.

So far, she is doing well. "Last semester, I passed with an A in all my subjects," said Nomvelo, who presented



her research in December 2021. She received the certificate for the best presentation and a 3,000-yen Amazon voucher.

Nomvelo is coping in a different country and different culture. She is fluent in Japanese, which she studied as soon as she joined the university. "Although my Japanese

is not perfect, I can handle a conversation. I find it easier to handle the conversation if I am the one who started it. The culture is different. It encourages people to be friendly and the communication style reflects the value placed on maintaining harmony. A large amount of communication is indirect or not spoken at all. However, if you pay attention to actions or certain sounds such as 'mmm', you can read between the lines. They avoid responses such as 'NO' or 'I CANNOT'. They will rather say they will think about it or you sometimes you get a 'Yes' that means 'no', depending on how the 'yes' is pronounced. For example, a lengthened yes (...Ye...s...) means no. I try my best to adopt the culture here so that I do not irritate people. I can only practice what I am aware of since some things are not spoken because they think it is common sense – for example, 'keep left and pass right' when you walk. For more information, please watch this video, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zIWnTzyZuSw>. Talking on the phone is not allowed on a train and you have to take off your shoes when you enter the house, or the fitting room in some shops. When I was staying at the student residence, I had to take off my shoes when I entered the building and

wear different shoes to walk inside. Another different pair was used in the bathroom,” said Nomvelo.

Japan's weather is very different from South African weather, but this student from Pietermaritzburg took this challenge in her stride. “Winter is very cold; summer is very hot. It is winter now in Japan; I rely on the aircon to adjust the temperature to a comfortable level. In summer, I use sunscreen.”

Nomvelo plans to join the renewable energy department at Eskom to apply the knowledge and skills she obtained during her stay in Japan. She says that although a large amount of power from renewable energy is supplied by independent power producers, it is Eskom's responsibility to integrate renewable energy into the grid. “Photovoltaic and wind power generation depend on weather conditions. That is why their output tends to fluctuate a lot. This is not healthy for the grid,” said Nomvelo. She adds that her main purpose in her research is to identify control strategies to integrate large-scale PV and wind farm power generation into the South African grid to help create a more sustainable power supply.



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MUT Engineering graduate takes over family business as CEO

Hlophani Dlamini, who graduated in 2021, is shaping and owning the future as the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Inghube Farming, a family-owned business he restructured with his siblings in 2020.

Dlamini's five-year journey to complete a Diploma in Civil Engineering at MUT was full of challenging and encouraging moments. He said that MUT was there for him all the way and he never gave up on his dreams of becoming an engineer.

Dlamini also acknowledged his parents who "instilled in us an inherent belief that we could do literally anything we put our minds to, and this included us being job creators within our region and district." He and his siblings Ms Sixolile, Mr Mbuso and Mr Phakamani Dlamini, who are all graduates of different institutions and have their own skills sets are in the farming and accommodation business. They have various livestock including pigs, rabbits, goats, sheep, and cows, and they also plant maize and vegetables on their two farms in Ulundi and Vryheid.

One of the key ingredients to strengthen the bonds between the family and the business is educating the next generation about family business matters. "My years at MUT empowered me with skills that I did not even know I would need in the family business. This is working for me and my business partners. It is one of the reasons that the Ingubhe Group Board entrusted me with the position of CEO," Dlamini said.

He added that he is lucky to have the opportunity to make a real impact on the family business, and not just be another number in a large organisation.

The siblings formalised the business in 2020 and have since managed to employ six permanent and 10 temporary employees. They also host students for experiential learning and exposure to the world of work.

Dlamini dreams of building a sustainable long-term vision for future generations and creating a platform to share experiences within the family business which



Dlamini farms with different animals

his father began. Having a good education helps him to shape and develop a vision and identity as the enterprise grows.



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